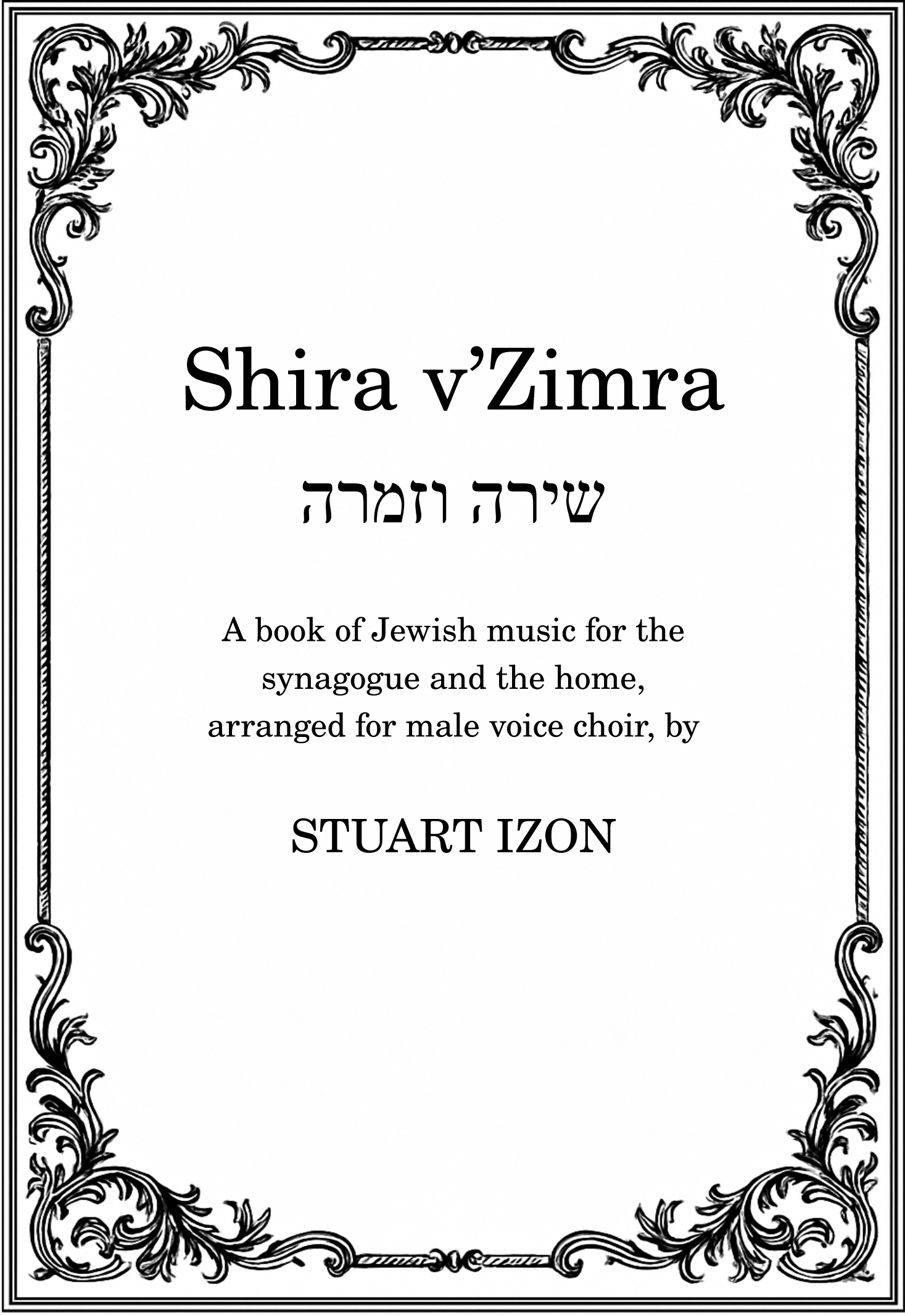




Shira v'Zimra

שירה וזמרה

A book of Jewish music for the
synagogue and the home,
arranged for male voice choir, by

STUART IZON

PREFACE

Jewish liturgical music today sits at a complicated crossroads.

Never before have we had such a wealth of recordings, manuscripts, digitised archives, and scholarly resources available at our fingertips. A curious singer can now explore forgotten traditions on YouTube, listen to historic cantorial recordings online, examine newly published or long-lost scores, and learn directly from communities across the world. In many ways, the tools to rediscover, revitalise, and reimagine our musical heritage have never been more abundant.

In many communities, however, the musical soundscape has simultaneously narrowed: services often feel increasingly homogeneous from week to week, and melodies that once varied widely have converged into a small set of familiar tunes. In the home, too, where Shabbat z'mirot once displayed extraordinary diversity, a similar contraction has taken place, with only a handful of melodies now widely known. One of the principal forces driving this change has been a shift in service leadership. In many communities today, davening is led far more frequently by ba'alei t'filah than by trained chazzanim. While this has opened the door for greater participation, it has also contributed to a weakening of the musical tradition. In contrast to the rabbinate—where rigorous study, credentialing, and apprenticeship are expected—there is often little formal preparation for those who lead the prayers. Many ba'alei t'filah learn primarily by ear, modelling what they have heard others do, without the grounding in nusach, modes, or the interpretive craft that once shaped the role of the chazzan. As a result, styles are emulated rather than understood, and improvisation gives way to repetition.

This shrinking of musical variety is closely linked to the fading of communal memory. Many of the melodies that were once widespread across Ashkenazi communities have disappeared as populations have moved, communities have merged, and local traditions have become diluted. Distinct regional and familial tunes that animated Jewish life for generations are no longer widely recognised or sung, and some exist now only in archival recordings or fragmentary recollection. As these traditions fade, the melodies that remain often shift in subtle but significant ways. Without strong transmission frameworks, melodic lines drift: harmonies are lost, and phrases are reshaped for ease or familiarity. The loss of improvisational fluency—once central to the role of the chazzan—leads to a reliance on formulas rather than modes, and on repetition rather than expressive interpretation. These shifts create an opening for new musical influences to enter the service, not always judiciously. Much contemporary Jewish music is written in popular or performance styles rather than specifically for liturgical use, yet these pieces often migrate into prayer settings. Orthodox pop has become common in synagogues, sometimes irrespective of its fit with the liturgical text or the emotional arc of the service.

Taken together, these dynamics illustrate why careful curation and thoughtful musical reflection are needed today. This book does not seek to impose a single "correct" musical tradition, but rather to illuminate the breadth of possibilities—resurfacing forgotten melodies, clarifying origins where possible, and celebrating the richness and variety that Jewish liturgical music has embodied across centuries.

Who this book is for

This book is written for anyone who seeks to lead, understand, or simply appreciate the music of the synagogue and the Jewish home. It is intended for professional chazzanim and for lay ba'alei t'filah who step forward to guide their communities in prayer. It is for choirs, for ensemble leaders, and for the keen admirer who delights in the musical fabric of the service even if they never intend to lead it themselves. Above all, it is for those who wish to deepen their connection to the tradition through melody.

What this book is and isn't

This book does not present itself as a scholarly thesis. I am not a musicologist, and I offer no footnotes or formal sourcing; instead, what follows is rooted in personal experience, observation, and engagement with synagogue music across communities. Nor is this a book of nusach. Nusach is the bedrock of chazzanut—a system of modes, motifs, and interpretative practices that guide the prayer leader through the liturgical cycle. It is a vast and beautiful discipline, but it is not the subject of this volume. Here, the focus is on melodies that sit above the layer of nusach: tunes that congregations sing, that choirs harmonise, and that service leaders weave into the davening. Some recitative passages appear here only insofar as they form part of a larger musical piece.

My focus is on material that can genuinely be performed as part of a liturgical service. I have avoided pure concert works that rely on instrumental accompaniment or high-art pieces which demand a level of virtuosity impractical for most congregations. The pieces included here are chosen for their accessibility: they are singable by the vast majority of leaders, whether seasoned chazzanim or casual ba'alei t'filah, with or without a choir. Nevertheless, every piece in this volume is presented in choral form. Even when a melody is typically sung in unison—whether by a single leader or a congregation—the harmony is included here to reveal the full musical architecture from which these pieces emerge. Harmony is not merely decorative: it is essential for understanding a composition's origins, its movement, and its emotional character. By exposing the underlying harmonic framework, this book aims to breathe life into the music, restoring depth, colour, and intention even for those who ultimately sing the melody alone.

Finally, this is not a halachic work. Despite being a book of music for male voice choir, it does not opine on questions such as the role of women's voices, or repetition of words in prayer texts.

Arrangement philosophy

Arranging and rearranging these pieces is not an act of reinvention but of stewardship. Many of the melodies in this book originated in musical worlds that no longer exist in the Orthodox synagogue: some were written for SATB mixed choirs, or for choirs of men and boys—ensembles that were once common but are now rare or no longer viable. To make these works usable today, their harmonic language must be adapted for the forces that contemporary communities actually have (if they have a choir at all). Other pieces were never fully arranged for voices, relying instead on instrumental accompaniment—often organ—whose harmonic foundation must be translated into voices if the music is to function in a fully a cappella environment. In some cases, the original harmony is unimaginative or stylistically mismatched with Jewish liturgical aesthetics. This book seeks to present harmonies which are faithful, functional, and stylistically appropriate without imposing modern idioms that would feel out of place. This act of

rescoring is not new. The editors of the Blue Book made similar adjustments, and arrangers across generations have adapted these pieces for their time; this volume stands in that lineage.

A further layer of adaptation involves text. Different communities use slightly different versions of certain prayers or piyyutim, and part of arranging involves choosing and rescoring the text. Pronunciation is standardised here according to *Havarah Yisraelit* for the sake of consistency, regardless of the provenance of the melody. Reaccenting, too, is sometimes necessary: many classic composers did not prioritise correct Hebrew stress patterns—whether due to limited Hebrew fluency or because musical considerations took precedence. My approach is to adjust the accentuation only where it preserves musical integrity and recognisability. This is a divisive subject, where some will feel strongly that reaccenting should be avoided entirely. However to me, to change nothing is to perpetuate mispronunciation; to change everything is to flatten the character of beloved melodies. The goal is a balanced, respectful middle path.

All arrangements in this book are written for four male parts in the MATB format (Melody, Alto, Tenor, Bass), a practice popularised by Stephen Glass. This format has several advantages over TTBB scoring, as the melody remains prominent both on the page and in the ear, and allows for a spacious harmonic texture. MATB resembles SATB visually on the page but functions differently. In particular, the Tenor line may go above the Melody line: therefore in performance, the Tenor part should be sung with sensitivity—often more lightly, or even in falsetto—so that it supports rather than competes with the melodic line.

In all these adaptations, I have tried to remain as close as possible to the spirit of the originals while making them singable, practical, and musically satisfying for the communities who will use them.

Recordings

During the Covid-19 pandemic, when many synagogues around the world were closed, I began a project to record some of this beautiful liturgical music. These recordings are multitrack performances of my own voice, layered into four-part harmony. They accompany this book as an aural counterpart to the written scores. They are not intended to be polished studio recordings; I chose to prioritise making a wide range of melodies available rather than producing a small number of meticulously engineered tracks. Their purpose is practical: to help singers internalise the music, to offer guidance where the page alone may not suffice, and to bring these settings to life. As noted above, this book is intended for a wide audience, and not everyone reads music fluently—or has the time to digest a score. These recordings therefore serve as an accessible entry point for those who prefer to learn by ear, offering a way into the repertoire that complements and supports the written notation.